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Rohler. The 2015 World Champion Julius Yego echoed Rohler's thoughts. "It was amazing. Before I even threw my best, I was joining the fun with the crowd. I got a season-best throw, and I am going home happy."

In the end, it was validation for Neeraj. In the week ahead of the NC Classic, the 27-year-old had gone on a promotional blitzkrieg, almost as if he was afraid the event had failed to stoke up the necessary attention.

"To see athletics getting this much support is what we wanted. It felt so good. This is a reward for the athletes' hard work. I wasn't just thinking like an athlete. There was

pressure, a different kind of pressure," said Neeraj after the meet.

The emotional toll of management that Neeraj spoke about was evident on the eve of the competition. The Indian athlete was fidgety at the pre-event press conference, a sense of apprehension about NC Classic's success writ large across his face.

The Neeraj who turned up for the post-event media interaction was far more relaxed. His smile was no longer weighed down by anxiety, while his words sang to the tune of relief.

"I was worrying about how things were being organised. Even the